
The Celebrated Ending-a-Sentence-with-a-Preposition Story

Two women are seated side by side at a posh dinner party, one a matron of the sort played in the old Marx Brothers movies by Margaret Dumont, except frostier, the other an easygoing southern gal, let's say, for the sake of the visuals, wearing a very pink and very ruffled evening gown.

Southern Gal, amiably, to Frosty Matron: So where y'all from?

Frosty Matron, no doubt giving Southern Gal a once-over through a lorgnette: I'm from a place where people don't end their sentences with prepositions.

Southern Gal, sweetly, after a moment's consideration: OK. So where y'all from, bitch?

THE LESSER SEVEN

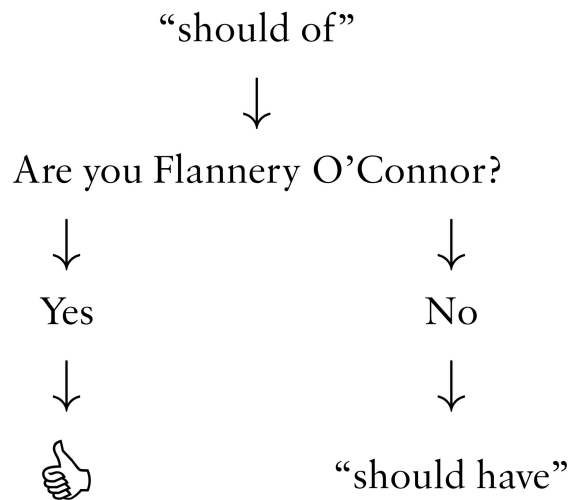
I'm sure there are many more secondary nonrules than these seven, but these are the ones I'm most often asked about (or challenged on), so:

1. Contractions Aren't Allowed in Formal Writing.

This may be a fine rule to observe if you want to sound as if you learned English on your native Mars, but there's not a goshdarn thing wrong with "don't," "can't," "wouldn't," and all the rest of them that people naturally use, and without them many a piece of writing would turn out stilted and wooden. The likes of "I'd've" and "should've" are perhaps a bit too loosey-goosey outside casual prose, but generally speaking: Contractions are why God invented the apostrophe, so make good use of both.

Speaking of "should've":

The Flannery O'Connor Flowchart



The correct construction is “should have” (also “could have,” “would have,” etc.). If you are not Flannery O'Connor, or Zora Neale Hurston, or William Faulkner, and you wish to convey the particular sound of a particular character's speech—and I warn you up front, more on it later, about the dangers of phonetic dialogue—please avail yourself of “should've,” “could've,” “would've,” and so forth. They sound precisely the same, no one will yell at you, and we'll all be a lot happier.

2. The Passive Voice Is to Be Avoided.

A sentence written in the passive voice is one whose subject would, in a sentence constructed in the active voice, be its object. That is:

Active Voice: The clown terrified the children.

Passive Voice: The children were terrified by the clown.

In a sentence written in the passive voice, the thing that is acted upon is frontloaded, and the thing doing the acting comes at the end. In either case, we can easily agree that clowns are terrifying.

Often, in a sentence constructed in the passive voice, the actor is omitted entirely. Sometimes this is done in an attempt to call attention to a problem without laying blame (“The refrigerator door was left open”) and sometimes, in weasel-like fashion, to avoid taking responsibility: “Mistakes were made,” for instance, which, uttered on various occasions by various Bushes, may well be the motto of that political dynasty.